hermitage of Sage Gautama, where Rama was destined to revive the former's wife Ahalya who had been cursed earlier. It was only thereafter that the brothers proceeded to Mithila to perform the feat with Shiva's bow.

For a nation like India, it is to be expected that there will be rivers and mountains to cross as it moves towards becoming a leading power. Some of them could be direct challenges, others a product of larger circumstances. There could be recurring issues, as indeed Lord Rama was to experience with the demon Maricha. At the end of the day, the rising of a power is an exercise in perseverance, endurance and mental strength. If we are to look for a contemporary reflection of these events where India is concerned, this may be in building its infrastructure, upgrading its human resources, countering territorial challenges, developing deep strengths, exercising the nuclear option and improving the quality of governance. As it moves on to the next stage of its rise, India, too, needs to broaden its vistas, be more aware of competitors and strengthen its comprehensive national power.

THE NEW MANDALA

In any assessment, it is relatively easy to point to individual events and outcomes to demonstrate a sense of change. That may not be altogether without merit, but it cannot be the full story. Even inflection points are just that; they only serve to highlight a larger trend. Given the scale of what India is seeking to do over an extended period, it would be completely natural to expect that there would be a comprehensive approach to achieving its goals. And indeed, that is exactly what has emerged steadily over this period.

Some facets required an occasion to be unveiled, such as the enunciation of the SAGAR outlook during a prime ministerial visit to Mauritius in 2015. In other cases, the rationale followed the action such as the formalization of the Neighbourhood First policy some months after the 2014 swearing-in ceremony or, as was the case with ASEAN and beyond, additional layers had to be added for 'Look East' to become 'Act East'.

But there were also stark strategic decisions, such as the commitment to propagate the message of Indo-Pacific. Sometimes, particular events were devised to make a new move, such as the Forum for India–Pacific Islands Cooperation (FIPIC) summits. On occasion, certain circumstances brought out latent thinking, a good example being the Voice of Global South Summit in the aftermath of Covid and Ukraine. As we near the end of a decade, the overall strategy is obviously very much clearer than it was at